

BEHAVIOURAL ECONOMICS IN ACTION:

Nudges to Boost Extracurricular Participation Among Students

Exploring how behavioural nudges can encourage greater involvement in extracurricular activities and promote holistic student development.



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Extracurricular activities are essential for holistic development, allowing students to explore their interests, build confidence, and develop skills outside the academic curriculum. Yet, in many schools and colleges, participation in extracurricular activities remains low due to various factors, such as parental pressure for academic excellence, lack of awareness, and limited institutional support. Applying behavioural economics—specifically the concept of "nudges"—offers a promising approach to encourage greater involvement in extracurricular activities among students. This explores how behavioural nudges can be utilized to create a vibrant extracurricular culture in educational institutions, promoting balanced personal growth and skill development.

The Problem: Low Extracurricular Participation Rates

In education system often emphasizes academic achievement over extracurricular engagement. Students are encouraged to prioritize their studies, and parents frequently view extracurricular activities as secondary, potentially detracting from academic success. This mindset, coupled with a lack of institutional support or infrastructure, limits students' opportunities to pursue interests in areas like sports, arts, and leadership. However, research consistently highlights the benefits of extracurricular involvement, such as improved social skills, emotional resilience, and increased academic motivation. Thus, increasing participation in these activities could significantly benefit students' overall development.

Behavioural Analysis: Understanding the Factors Behind Low Participation

To design effective nudges, we must understand the cognitive biases and psychological factors influencing students' decisions regarding extracurricular activities. Key factors include:

1. Status Quo Bias: Students may stick to their usual routines (focused on academics) instead of exploring extracurricular options.
2. Social Proof: Students are more likely to participate if they see their peers actively involved.
3. Present Bias: The immediate effort required to participate in extracurricular activities can deter students from considering the long-term benefits.

Addressing these biases with strategic nudges can help create a supportive environment that encourages students to engage in diverse extracurricular pursuits.

Proposed Nudge Interventions:

1. Default Enrolment in Extracurricular Clubs

-Automatically enrol students in at least one extracurricular club upon admission, allowing them to "opt-out" rather than "opt-in" to the club. This intervention leverages the concept of default choice, making extracurricular engagement the norm rather than the exception.

2. Peer Ambassador Programs

-Select enthusiastic students as "extracurricular ambassadors" who encourage their peers to join clubs and activities. Ambassadors can showcase the benefits of participation, share personal experiences, and provide support to new members.

3. Incentivizing Participation through Points and Rewards

- Implement a points system that rewards students for attending extracurricular activities. Points could be redeemed for privileges, such as extra library hours, priority registration, or certificates of achievement. This approach provides immediate, tangible incentives for participation.

4. Regular Extracurricular Showcases and Competitions

- Organize regular showcases and inter-school competitions, highlighting the achievements of students in various clubs. This increases visibility and provides an opportunity for students to gain recognition for their talents, inspiring others to participate.

5. Parental Engagement Workshops

- Conduct workshops to educate parents on the benefits of extracurricular activities, emphasizing how they complement academic success. Providing success stories and data on career outcomes for students with strong extracurricular backgrounds can help shift parental attitudes.

6. Highlighting the Benefits and Long-Term Gains

- Display information on how extracurricular involvement positively impacts employability, skill development, and academic performance. Place posters, flyers, or social media posts around campus and on websites, featuring testimonials from alumni who benefited from their involvement.

Implementing and Evaluating Nudge Interventions

For these nudges to be effective, educational institutions must take a systematic approach. Schools and colleges should identify their unique student demographics and tailor these interventions accordingly. Regular surveys, feedback from students and parents, and participation analytics can help assess the impact of these nudges. Institutions could collaborate with behavioural economists to refine their strategies and ensure the nudges remain relevant and impactful.

1. Limited Infrastructure and Facilities

- According to the 'Annual Status of Education Report (ASER) 2022', only 45% of rural government schools in India have a playground. The lack of basic sports infrastructure is a common barrier that limits students' opportunities to engage in physical extracurricular activities.

- A study by the 'National Institute of Educational Planning and Administration (NIEPA)' found that only 15-20% of Indian schools are equipped with facilities like music rooms or arts studios. This limited access makes it difficult for students interested in creative extracurriculars to explore their interests.

- National Sample Survey Office (NSSO) 2017-18: Only around 15% of Indian schools reported having sufficient sports equipment. In urban schools, access to equipment was slightly better at 20%, but in rural schools, this figure was significantly lower.

2. Parental Emphasis on Academics Over Extracurriculars

- In a 2020 survey by 'EduSports', 76% of parents in India prioritized academic achievements over extracurricular participation, citing concerns about academic performance and career preparation. Parents often discourage participation in extracurriculars due to the intense pressure surrounding competitive exams in India.

- A 2018 report by 'Boston Consulting Group' and 'The Central Square Foundation' indicated that Indian parents, particularly in low- and middle-income families, viewed extracurriculars as secondary, with 60% believing they "distract" students from studies.

3. Student Attitudes and Perceptions

- A study conducted in Delhi by 'Jamia Millia Islamia University' found that 40% of students perceived extracurricular activities as a "waste of time," largely due to pressure to focus on academics. This perception was more pronounced among students in higher secondary classes (11th and 12th grades) who felt compelled to focus exclusively on entrance exams for engineering, medicine, and other professional fields.

- According to 'Teach For India' (2021), only about 30% of students in low-income schools expressed an interest in extracurriculars due to a lack of exposure and motivation from their surroundings.

4. 'Gender Disparity in Participation'

- The 'ASER 2021' report also found that girls are less likely than boys to participate in extracurricular activities, particularly in rural areas, due to social expectations and limited availability of gender-inclusive programs. This disparity was further exacerbated by lack of facilities like girls' changing rooms or sports equipment tailored for female students.

- A survey by the 'World Bank' in partnership with the 'National Council of Educational Research and Training (NCERT)' found that only 25% of girls in rural secondary schools participated in sports activities, compared to 55% of boys.

5. Impact of Extracurricular Participation on Student Outcomes

- A 2019 study by 'KPMG' in partnership with 'Education World' revealed that students who participated in extracurricular activities demonstrated a 15% higher improvement in overall cognitive and emotional development compared to those who did not participate.

- University of Delhi conducted a study that showed students who engaged in extracurricular activities exhibited higher levels of self-esteem, motivation, and academic performance. The study found a 12% improvement in grades among students who participated in structured extracurricular programs over a one-year period.

- The National Council of Applied Economic Research (NCAER) in 2022 conducted a survey that found students who participated in extracurriculars were more likely to report better mental health outcomes, indicating lower levels of stress compared to their peers who did not participate in any activities.

How is it related with modern era in different phases of a student life?

Extracurricular activities play a crucial role in adolescent development, particularly in fostering identity formation and socio-emotional growth during this pivotal phase (Berger et al., 2020). These structured activities, occurring outside core academic subjects, provide adolescents with opportunities to develop practical skills, positive peer relationships, and essential life values (Ren et al., 2021; Ren & Zhang, 2020). As integral components of the educational environment, extracurriculars support emotional, physical, and moral development, enabling students to build teamwork, leadership skills, and social awareness (Shaffer, 2019). In some countries, such as Indonesia, these activities are formally regulated to align with national education goals, ensuring that students have the chance to develop their potential holistically (Regulation of the Minister of National Education of the Republic of Indonesia No 62 of 2014).

However, access to extracurricular activities is often unequal, with students from lower-income backgrounds facing limited opportunities, highlighting challenges in achieving inclusive education (Kosaretsky & Ivanov, 2019). Additionally, extracurriculars serve as constructive outlets in an era of globalization and digital influence, helping to counter moral challenges faced by today's adolescents (Sahin, 2018). While prior studies have examined various aspects, including entrepreneurship, character education, and academic performance (Adisel et al., 2022; Setiawan et al., 2021; Fujiyama et al., 2021; Rahman et al., 2021), specific research on the link

between extracurricular participation and character development is limited. This study aims to address that gap by exploring how extracurricular activities influence character education and identifying factors that may strengthen or weaken this impact.

1. **Massification of Higher Education:** The trend of massification refers to the significant increase in participation in higher education, with **‘one-third of the global school-leaver age group now participating’**, and the rate increasing by **‘1% per year’** (Marginson, 2016). This growth poses challenges for institutions, including a need to provide support for larger student bodies and ensure successful transitions from previous educational stages.

2. **Marketization and Employability Focus:** The shift towards marketization has redefined students as consumers who demand value from their education, often measured through employability outcomes (Harrison and Risler, 2015). Governments and students expect universities to prioritize employability, so the tuition investment is repaid through job opportunities (Elwick and Cannizzaro, 2017).

3. **Role of Extra-Curricular Activities:** Extra-curricular activities are seen as key in building skills not often included in academic curricula. They help students develop "soft skills" like ‘communication, team-work, and problem-solving’, which are highly valued by employers (Clark et al., 2015; Maher and Graves, 2008). For instance:

- **Social benefits:** Extra-curricular activities build social capital, networks, and a sense of belonging, which can lead to improved motivation and better academic performance (Osterman, 2000).

- **Personal benefits:** Participation can lead to increased resilience, time-management, and organization skills, which indirectly support academic success (Thompson et al., 2013).

4. **Impact on Academic Performance:** Research suggests three models explaining the relationship between extra-curricular activities and academic performance:

- **Zero-Sum Model:** Suggests time in extra-curriculars could detract from academic study, though this model is now largely outdated (Torenbeek et al., 2010).

- **Development Model:** Indicates a positive, indirect impact on academics, with benefits like time management and social connection.

- **Threshold Model:** Argues that extra-curricular involvement is beneficial up to a certain level, beyond which it can be detrimental if it overwhelms academic commitments (Seow and Pan, 2014).

5. **Competency and Skill Development:** Employers seek graduates with skills beyond technical knowledge, and students view extra-curriculars as vital for acquiring these. Skills gained through extra-curricular activities include ‘communication, teamwork, self-confidence, and problem-solving’, which are not always developed through traditional lectures (Maher and Graves, 2008; Fink, 2013).

6. **Evidence of Benefits:** Extra-curricular activities enhance employability skills and are documented in ‘ePortfolios’ or ‘digital portfolios’, which positively impact self-regulated learning and help graduates demonstrate non-academic competencies to employers (Nguyen and Ikeda, 2015; Zimmerman, 2008).

7. **Gaps and Future Directions:** While extra-curricular activities are broadly seen as beneficial, more empirical research is needed to understand their full impact, especially beyond employability. Current research is mostly quantitative and often focused on specific skill acquisition, leaving a gap in understanding broader personal development outcomes.

In summary, extra-curricular activities in modern higher education play a crucial role in both skill development and social engagement, which help students thrive academically and professionally. However, understanding their impact holistically requires further investigation.

Recommendations:

- Improve Infrastructure: Schools should prioritize investing in basic infrastructure like sports fields, art studios, and music rooms, especially in rural and low-income areas.
- Increase Parental Awareness: Educating parents on the benefits of extracurriculars can help shift their focus from solely academic success to holistic development.
- Promote Gender Inclusivity: Schools should implement gender-inclusive programs and facilities, enabling equal participation across all types of extracurriculars for both boys and girls.
- Incentivize Participation: Schools and colleges can offer incentives like academic credits, certificates, or recognition, which can encourage students to participate actively in extracurricular activities.

This data highlights the need for targeted interventions to address the structural, interpersonal, and intrapersonal barriers that currently prevent students from fully benefiting from extracurricular participation in Indian schools and colleges.

Conclusion: Building a Balanced Educational Environment

Behavioural nudges hold significant potential to revolutionize extracurricular participation in schools and colleges. By understanding students' and parents' psychological tendencies, schools can implement subtle, non-intrusive interventions that encourage students to explore their interests and develop skills beyond academics. These efforts can help create a more balanced, enriching educational environment, fostering a generation of well-rounded individuals equipped for a dynamic world.

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